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War, widowhood, and maternal grief in *Jacob's Room*

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ABSTRACT
This article repositions Virginia Woof's *Jacob's Room* as a feminist elegy centred on the maternal figure of Betty Flanders. Drawing on the concept of affective apophasis, it argues that Virginia Woolf reframes elegy through silence, atmosphere, and absence rather than direct expression. Because of her dual identity as widow and bereaved mother, Betty emerges as an Everywoman of the Great War whose grief unites private and public mourning. Grounded in feminist theories of grievability, this analysis shows how Woolf anticipates continuing questions about whose losses are acknowledged and whose remain unheard.

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Mourning's failure, form's invention

Widely recognised as a modernist elegy for a generation of young men lost to the Great War[1], Virginia Woolf's *Jacob's Room* registers the aftermath of mass death through formal dissolution and epistemological rupture. The novel's dismantling of character, causality and closure stages Woolf's reflection on the expressive limits of language – a problem Woolf explicitly confronts in 'On Not Knowing Greek', where she asserts that Greek drama can 'poin[t] at but cannot indicate' transcendent meaning, which hovers 'just on the far side of language'.[2] The tragedy, for Woolf, lies not in our inability to feel, but in the insufficiency of language to hold what is most deeply felt. Still, she insists upon the literary attempt to gesture, if not to name, and, in this way, anticipates a constellation of later theorists who will begin to think about trauma and pain as sites that 'resis[t]' narrative structure and 'destro[y]' language.[3] But Woolf was already composing in that key, insisting that literature meet unspeakable emotion with formal invention.[4]

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Many have written about the psychic rupture the Great War induced, for it was a war that rendered obsolete the illusion that death could remain peripheral to ordinary life. In his 1915 essay 'Thoughts for the Times on War and Death', Freud registers this breach as epistemological 'disillusionment': it was 'bloody' and 'destructive', 'cruel', and 'embittered' and 'implacable'.[5] What crumbled was not only the symbolic distance by which bourgeois culture had insulated itself from mortality, but the very capacity of language to mediate trauma. Paul Fussell observes that, for many soldiers, the war could not be narrated without falsification: 'The smell rising from the bloated bodies', he writes, 'was beyond description'.[6] Louis Simpson similarly underscores the visceral brutality of trench warfare, calling it 'almost entirely physical', too immediate to be contained by language.[7] In his meditation on elegy, David Shaw reaches the same impasse, claiming that 'every elegy sooner or later reaches the limits of language'.[8]

Whereas Fussell and Simpson lament the irrepresentability of trench warfare, *Jacob's Room* pursues a different register of grief – one no less bodily, but historically muted and symbolically unattended. I propose that we extend Woolf's subject from the battlefield[9] to the maternal homefront, from the soldier's silence to the mother's. The failure of language confronted by the Great War becomes, for Woolf, the occasion to build a new elegiac form and compositional ethic. I advance the term *affective apophasis* (defined below) as both the novel's method and its argument. While Jacob's death remains the narrative's ostensible telos, it is Betty's sorrow that endures. The result is not a novel about mourning, but a novel that formally mourns. At the heart of it is Betty Flanders, the novel's Everywoman of war: a widow and mother whose sorrow is woven into the syntax and dispersed into narrative atmosphere. Her grief becomes Woolf's attempt at exploring the nuance of war's remembrance.

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Traditionally associated with mystical theology, apophasis names a rhetorical method used to describe what lies beyond comprehension. God, for instance, is defined not through attributes but through refusals: God is *not* finite, *not* corporeal, *not* knowable. This method safeguards the mystery of the divine by maintaining the limits of human language. Similar rhetorical strategies are found in how grief is often expressed not by naming the lost person directly but by describing the silence that follows their death. A person mourning might say, 'There's no one to call in the evening anymore', or 'The house feels empty', or, holding out a pair of old shoes, ask, 'What am I to do with these?',[10] invoking presence by describing what is no longer there. Woolf's modernist elegiac form operates in this key. Rather than narrating maternal loss through exposition or dialogue, she constructs emotional worlds where absence becomes a palpable force that is socially circulated, psychologically embedded, and formally sustained. Apophasis, in

this sense, becomes a generative aesthetic principle, allowing Woolf to hold space for maternal grief through its very inarticulability.

Yet this framework alone cannot account for the embodied, relational and even gendered grief Woolf depicts. Critics of modernist mourning such as Jahan Ramazani, Melissa Zeiger and Tammy Clewell describe Woolf's elegiac writing as a refusal of consolation – expressing grief through silence and fragmentation.[11] These readings often stop at language, treating silence as a stylistic devise rather than an affective condition. What I term *affective apophasis* extends this view by attending to how Woolf's silence generates emotional connection. In this sense, atmospheric silence carries the weight of what cannot be spoken, and, in so doing, names Woolf's way of writing and our way of reading literature that stays with grief instead of resolving it.[12]

This affective dimension draws on Brian Massumi's definition of affect as an unconscious 'intensity' that exceeds language,[13] and with Sara Ahmed's theory of emotion as relational, circulating between bodies and attaching to scenes and objects. In Woolf's fiction, these affective residues adhere to ambient form; feelings 'stick' to the atmospheric weight of what cannot be voiced.[14] Her short story 'Kew Gardens' captures this same tension between heaviness and transience, describing 'words with short wings for their heavy body of meaning',[15] an image that suggests how language itself strains under emotional weight, embodying the effort to hold what exceeds expression.

While psychoanalytic and poststructural accounts of mourning – from Freud's conception of internalised loss[16] to Boym's reflections on nostalgia[17] and Derrida's 'work of mourning'[18] – help explain grief's persistence beyond death, Woolf's innovation lies in how she locates this persistence in the maternal body and in form itself. Her fiction transforms what Freud treats as psychic absorption into a texture of feeling that moves through absence. In Woolf's fiction, the mothers who vanish (Theresa Vinrance in *The Voyage Out*, for example; or, Mrs Ramsay in *To the Lighthouse*) never fully depart; their absence structures mood, character and form until the novels close.[19] Affective apophasis names this narrative process. It describes how Woolf reinvents elegy by withholding the closure of traditional elegy. Readers are denied a clear image of Jacob, we don't get a cathartic moment of mourning, and we certainly don't get a structured path to consolation; instead, Woolf shows us the *conditions* of grief: rooms left empty, sentences that break apart, objects that outlive their owners. Mrs Flanders' grief isn't voiced directly. It's ambient, carried along in the elemental motifs of wind and rain.[20]

Grief and the lexicon of absence

Despite her narrative centrality, Betty Flanders has long remained a peripheral figure in Woolf criticism, overshadowed by the interpretive enigmas that

cluster around Jacob.[21] The novel's reputation as an experimental elegy for the fallen soldier has dominated its reception, directing critical attention toward Woolf's treatment of masculine absence rather than maternal grief. Yet as early as 1932, Winifred Holtby recognised that Woolf's fiction turned on what remains after loss. She describes Woolf's silences as 'presences by negation', traces of emotion that persist through erasure and acquire structural force.[22]

Later critics extend this recognition into formal terms, among them Kate Flint who names the tendencies Holtby observes with precision. Flint notes that critical focus has remained fixed on 'form and on the enigmatic young man', and in doing so, 'ignore[s] the reworking of women's consciousness throughout the novel'.[23] Over thirty years later, that scholarly gaze is still fixed on Jacob. While Neverow acknowledges Betty's 'substantial presence', her analysis – like that of Galen Bunting and Alice Kelly – tethers Betty's grief to Jacob's development.[24] Bunting describes him as 'the son of a widowed mother',[25] while Kelly, more attentive to the novel's formal cues, observes that *Jacob's Room* 'begins and ends with a female mourner: a grieving widow, who has simultaneously lost her son'.[26] It is this simultaneity – widowhood and bereaved motherhood – that gives Betty's sorrow its unique depth and elegiac charge.

David Bradshaw and Linda Martin offer two of the more detailed close readings of Mrs Flanders in the Scarborough beach scene. Bradshaw's approach is speculative – he admits to 'read[ing] [his] way into a wilderness of [his] own imagining'[27] – but he nonetheless highlights the maternal weight of the novel's early pages. His questions underscore what he describes as an atmosphere 'pregnant with references to childbirth and maternity … as if Woolf has gone out of her way to keep them continuously in view'.[28] For all of the questions Bradshaw leaves unanswered (*Why does Betty's writing hand evoke an image of ejaculatory ink*?), he provides compelling claims that maternity frames the novel's emotional structure.[29]

Yet even these readings often subordinate Betty's grief. Martin describes Betty's 'ambient sadness' as a response to 'a tragic accident',[30] but she does not unpack the nature of that accident, nor its implications for Betty's inner world. Her treatment of mourning remains instrumental – evoked primarily to scaffold Jacob's emotional arc. 'This is a text supposedly written for the purpose of grieving the men lost in the Great War', Martin writes,[31] and so Betty's sorrow becomes a submerged chord in a larger symphony of male absence. Such occlusions are not incidental. They are symptomatic of a broader critical pattern in which female grief is marginalised within broader narratives of loss – one that mirrors the cultural silencing of women's mourning during and after the Great War. Woolf revisits this imbalance in *Mrs. Dalloway*, where Lady Bexborough receives the telegram announcing her son's death amid a London bazaar. The moment passes

almost without comment, her loss folded into the background of civic life.[32] The scene condenses the same erasure that shapes *Jacob's Room* when private devastation gets absorbed by public decorum.

As Susan Grayzel has documented, women's grief in wartime Britain was rendered both hypervisible and structurally unintelligible – recruited by the state as emblematic of patriotic sacrifice yet denied narrative space to express itself on its own terms.[33] Grayzel reveals how the state's ceremonial recognition of women's losses masked institutional neglect: pensions were delayed, emotional needs were unmet and the affective labour of grief was conscripted into the rhetoric of moral endurance. Sorrow could be voiced only if tempered by restraint; mourning could be legitimised only if reframed as submission. Even feminist literary criticism, as Nosheen Khan suggests, has at times absorbed these ideological constraints, reading women's wartime writing through a lens of redemptive sentimentality.[34] Yet as Carol Acton argues in her analysis of Vera Brittain, such readings may underestimate the immense pressure placed upon women to locate meaning where none was given, to translate devastation into moral clarity even as their male peers dismantled such ideologies from within.[35]

Woolf, acutely attuned to these entrapments, composes *Jacob's Room* within this historical and rhetorical enclosure, and, in so doing, she imagines Mrs Flanders as a deeply affective site of elegiac labour. The novel's revisions support this reading. As Flint notes, drawing on G. Thomas Tanselle's theory of vertical revision, Woolf's manuscript underwent a series of alterations that changed the work's very character and direction.[36] Flint's account is confirmed by later editorial work: Edward Bishop's transcription of the *Jacob's Room* holograph and Stuart Clarke and David Bradshaw's introduction to the Cambridge edition both note that Woolf's earliest draft began with Jacob himself and that she later revised the opening to centre Betty Flanders.[37] In moving the novel's first perspective from son to mother, Woolf displaced the conventional subject of elegy (the fallen man) and replaced him with the woman who endures. This compositional act performs what the novel will go on to theorise: namely, an affective apophasis in which female consciousness becomes the site through which mourning begins.

The widow: naming loss in negation

Having traced how scholarship has often silenced Betty's significance, I'd like now to consider how the novel itself exposes the silencing mechanisms built into language itself. The occlusion of women's grief in both public commemoration and critical discourse reflects a more profound elision, and that is the absence of language adequate to express maternal sorrow, broadly defined. Because women's mourning was rendered politically useful yet personally illegible, Woolf deepens the crisis by exposing its lexical consequences. In

the novel's first full character description, the narrator remarks that Betty 'was, of course, a widow in her prime'.[38] The word *widow* itself comes from the Sanskrit *vidh*, meaning 'to lack' and the Latin *viduus*, meaning 'bereft'. From its origins, the term defines a woman through loss, naming absence rather than presence.[39] As Marjo Buitelaar observes, the widow stands on 'an indefinite threshold between life and death', having 'looked death in the eye' yet remaining unincorporated into the society that surrounds her.[40] She exists in a suspended state that exposes the fault line of a culture unable to contain a woman outside patriarchal designation.[41]

In her work on war widows, Erika Kuhlman estimates that the war left roughly three million widows across Europe and more than 190,000 in Britain, most raising children under sixteen.[42] The math is bleak. As Van Emden calculates, over 53,000 of those widows shouldered the burden of raising three or more children.[43] These numbers testify to the scale of loss while mutually intimating the emotional and structural precarity imposed on women. Young, often impoverished, and weighed down by maternal responsibility, widows were expected to remarry or recede. Their visibility as public mourners came with conditions: accept your suffering as noble, render your loss patriotic and do not linger.

What emerged was a grief that publicly honoured the widow's role while privately emptying it of expression. A century later, the pattern holds. As Kuhlman notes, the war widow 'has rarely been a topic of interest to historians', with most treatments relying on symbolic archetypes or legal records rather than lived experience.[44] This systematic neglect would not have surprised Woolf, who, as Christine Froula reminds us, recognised the forces that denied women full cultural legitimacy, even in mourning: women, Froula contends, were not 'fully legitimated participants in history and culture'.[45]

In *Jacob's Room*, Woolf reclaims that illegitimacy and refigures it as central to the work of mourning. While Seabrook Flanders clearly dies in an 'accident', the language of his demise has militaristic flair. As Susan Bennett Smith observes, Seabrook's refusal to change his boots 'connotes militarism and manly stubbornness, both of which prove fatal'.[46] His burial – 'enclosed in three shells' – evokes both artillery and coffin, while the narrator's aside, that he was 'one of a company', positions him within the lexicon of war death.[47] The very name Flanders – shared by Betty and Jacob – invokes the killing fields of Ypres and Passchendaele. As Zwerdling notes, 'Though Seabrook Flanders was no war victim, he too died young, before the world knew what to call him',[48] and the inscription on his tomb – 'Merchant of the City' – strikes the same discordant note as many war memorials, which 'are not notable for their realism'.[49] In this light, we are encouraged to read Betty as an archetypal war widow. As Bishop argues, *Jacob's Room* seeks 'to

honor the non-combatants … [and] memorialise not only Jacob, but those who are left behind by the impending war'.[50]

Descriptions of Mrs Flanders as poverty-stricken align with the historical reality that many widows, especially young mothers, fell into economic hardship. Their vulnerability only intensified over time, as pension systems lagged and remarrying became both socially mandated and structurally difficult. Betty lives in 'barren' circumstances with her sons, housed in rented rooms under the watchful eye of landladies and neighbours.[51] She tells Captain Barfoot that the front room is empty though 'satisfactorily arranged'.[52] Her family is 'packed [in] like herrings in a barrel', and she is 'forced to stand the perambulator which the landlady quite naturally won't allow'.[53] Mr Floyd, we learn, offers free Latin lessons for her sons, a gesture coded as charity. In this landscape of curtailed possibility, even her aspirations are modest: 'they were all alive'; she 'wished she could buy Garfit's acre'.[54]

Mrs Flanders's struggles are shaped and exacerbated by her societal context. The women of Scarborough pity her, yet their sympathy reinforces her isolation. Mrs Jarvis, the rector's wife, ponders Betty presumably praying over her young son's heads at church and thinks, 'marriage is a fortress and widows stray solitary in the open fields, picking up stories, gleaning a few golden straws, lonely, unprotected, poor creatures'.[55] Indeed, Mrs Flanders is unprotected; her only 'fortress' is the exposed Roman Camp at the top of Dods Hill.[56]

Because widowhood is bound up in discourses of patriarchal ideology (widows, like Evelyn M.'s mother in *The Voyage Out*, were often distrusted because they did not have a male head of household to keep them in check),[57] and because Mrs Flanders does not have a husband in Scarborough, she is isolated and deprived of support from the other women. Mrs Flanders's intimate knowledge of loss makes her an outsider among the ladies of Scarborough, and as such, she's never far removed from the ladies' gossip. In one key passage, the women in the area recount for one another her movements: 'Now she's going up the hill with little John', said 'Mrs Cranch to Mrs Garfit'.[58] '"Mrs Flanders" – "Poor Mrs Flanders" – "Dear Mrs Flanders" – "She's very attractive still"'.[59] We learn that Betty Flanders, referred to in the lines that follow as 'the widow', brings her boys 'on summer's days … to stand' at Seabrook's tombstone.[60] While the women feel 'kindly' to her in these moments, and the men raise their hats 'higher than usual', Woolf's tone implies that this is a show of custom rather than an attempt at comfort, as not a single person approaches her.[61] The image evokes amateur war photographer Margaret Hall's photograph *Grave In 'No Man's Land'*, in which a female figure stands alone, solemn, in a forlorn landscape before a cross (Figure 1). Like Hall's mourner, Mrs Flanders is a

Figure 1. Hall, Margaret. 'Grave in "No Man's Land"' (1918–1919), gelatin silver print (The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, Gift of Mrs Anson Phelps Stokes, 1961).

solitary figure whose grief is both public and private, her widowhood suspended in a space of ambient mourning.

What's more, Betty lives within a continuous sense of loss: She thinks of her brother Morty's 'downfall and possible demise'.[62] She considers Captain Barfoot, 'lame and want[ing] two fingers on the left hand, having served his country'.[63] She tells her boys of poor Mr Curnow who 'lost his eye' in a 'gunpowder explosion'.[64] Such a condition puts her in a state of constant anticipatory mourning. Which is to say, her grief is not simply confined to what has already been lost; it leans forward, always bracing for what has not yet arrived. The novel renders this unease early, long before death becomes explicit. Jacob returns late from chasing moths, and the air ruptures: 'The tree had fallen, though it was a windless night. … A volley of pistol-shots suddenly in the depths of the wood'.[65] Betty, startled, mistakes her son for a burglar. The moment, minor in plot, resounds symbolically, as grief presses atmospherically into the text before the fact of it arrives. This is Woolf's elegiac design, for as Wall observes, the novel's 'prolepses suggest that the text's elegiac gestures and form are present from the outset'.[66] Woolf does not withhold Jacob's death as revelation; she constructs a world already vibrating with its inevitability. We are not meant to realise 'only near the end that the story [we] have been reading … [ends] with

Jacob's death'.[67] The atmosphere is mourning all along, though Woolf's elegy does not end with widowhood. The novel widens its register of loss, turning from the social category of the widow to the unnamable condition of the bereaved mother.

The mother unnamed

While Woolf's elegy begins by positioning Betty as a widow, it does not remain there, for, by the novel's end, her grief is doubled when she becomes a bereaved mother. Claudia Siebrecht captures the complexity of this convergence in her description of the 'double-helix' at the core of many women's war narratives.[68] While Margaret Hall's *Grave in 'No Man's Land'* distils widowhood into a solitary female figure marked by silence and absence, Alphonse Grebel's image *Tristesse* (Figure 2) extends the field of mourning, placing the mother beside the grave of her fallen son. It is here, in the quiet visual vocabulary of maternal loss, that Woolf's elegy gathers its second axis. Betty is no longer only the woman left behind by an accidental death; she is also the mother of a son whose disappearance, though yet unspoken, has already begun to saturate the text.

Woolf resists compartmentalisation, as the novel does not distinguish clearly between griefs. Instead, Woolf binds them together in a poetics of accumulation, where meaning emerges through accrual and echo. We might think of Betty's grief as a kind of *portmanteau*, drawing on Shilo McGiff and

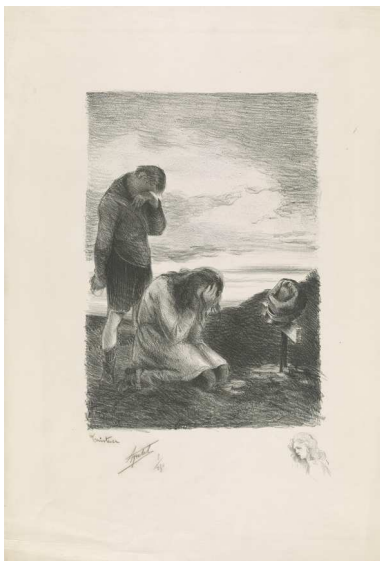

Figure 2. Alphonse Grebel (1885–1968), *Tristesse*, lithographic print, Paris, c. 1914–1916. Courtesy of Alamy.

Valerie Favre's recent reading of Woolf's characters as 'multi-folded', distributed across 'many things working together', shaped by accretion rather than singularity.[69] Drawing on Sara Ahmed's theory of affective attachments and Rita Felski's insistence on the associative density of character, McGiff and Favre argue that Woolf's figures resist individuation in favour of accretive resonance. 'The very idea of character is shredded, dissolved',[70] Felski writes, and yet Woolf's creations remain marked by their 'capacity to gather, to carry, to endure'.[71] Betty Flanders exemplifies this structural doubleness as a character that absorbs the emotional charge of widowhood and maternal bereavement alike, without ever parsing them into separable strands.

This layered grief performs multiple functions. First, it allows Betty to stand for the multitude of women whose domestic worlds were quietly unmade by war as their husbands and sons slipped into the rhetoric of national glory, even as their bodies and legacies dissolved into private pain. Second, it renders Betty both omen and embodiment – she is at once the mother who grieves and the mother who will grieve, a figure of anticipation whose sorrow stretches across the novel's temporal fabric. And third, her compositional role supplies *Jacob's Room* with its most essential formal principle: a recursive, atmospheric elegy that resists closure while it loops and lingers, accumulating grief as an ambient condition.

The portmanteau of widowhood and maternal bereavement forces the reader to explore the shifting resonances of the word *mother* itself. As the novel begins to centre on Betty's evolving grief, *mother* thickens into *Mother*, a term that now must carry the intimate labour of raising children *and* the symbolic burden of national mourning at once. The small, lowercase *mother* chases young boys (and chickens) and climbs Dods Hill with a perambulator in tow. The capitalised *Mother*, by contrast, looms as a cultural construct, abstracted into a figure of sacrifice, invoked in memorials and imagined by the state as moral ballast for the war's devastation. As I've said, Woolf does not fully disentangle these identities. Instead, she allows their interference to remain by tracing how the personal *mother* flickers beneath the symbolic *Mother* and exposing how domestic labour and sacrificial expectation echo across the same affective field.

mother:

From the novel's opening pages, Betty Flanders is, unmistakably, a mother who manages the soft and sharp edges of domestic life with a young family. Like so many tasked with caregiving in times of precarity, Betty moves through the world embodying what Sara Ruddick, in *Maternal Thinking*, calls the labour of 'attentive love' – a practice defined not by sentimentality (or biological gender, for that matter), but by a steady commitment to 'preservative love, nurturance, and training'.[72] This form of maternal consciousness emerges in improvisational acts. In the opening lines, Mrs

Flanders tries to write while her boys play at the beach. This is a gesture that anticipates the maternal self-sacrifice Woolf will render more fully in *To the Lighthouse*, where Mrs Ramsay gives herself over to the needs of her family (and the emotionally taxing demands of her husband) simply to earn a few quiet moments of solitude. Like when she finally gets James tucked into bed one evening: 'It was a relief. … For now she need not think about anybody. She could be herself, by herself. And that was what now she often felt the need of – to think; well not even to think. To be silent; to be all alone'.[73] Thus we see Mrs Flanders sitting at the beach, crying and writing – alone with her grief for a few quiet minutes – and then sighing inevitably when Archer interrupts with the news that Jacob has scampered off.[74] She ends her writing with a quick dash on the envelope and a slap on her coat. In various scenes, the narrator rattles off Betty's actions in list-like fashion. In a single moment, Betty, 'hurr[ying] up the steep lane', is 'swinging her bag, clutching her parasol, holding Archer's hand, and telling the story of the gunpowder explosion in which poor Mr Curnow had lost his eye'.[75] Betty is the definition of maternal multi-tasking.

Betty's 'blankness of mind', the narrator explains, comes from a mind in overdrive: 'combined with profusion, mother wit, old wives' tales, haphazard ways, moments of astonishing daring, humor, and sentimentality'. In one example, she turns to Arthur and questions, 'What did I ask you to remember?' When the boy admits that he's forgotten what it is he's supposed to be remembering, Betty chimes in 'humorously' that she, too, has forgotten. Moments later, the referent of this forgetfulness is revealed: 'The meat!' 'She had forgotten the meat'.[76] In a second example, Betty sits to write a letter to Mr Floyd. 'Dear Mr Floyd', she begins, before a sudden intrusion hits her: '"Did I forget about the cheese?" she wondered. … No, she had told Rebecca that the cheese was in the hall' – at which point she resumes her letter.[77]

Betty is not absent-minded. She is saturated! And to make matters worse, sleep, that fragile reprieve, evades her. Men, like Jacob's Professor Huxtable, sit 'for hours' until sleep arrives unbidden, but Betty is kept awake by Archer, who 'had been awake again last night',[78] and by Jacob. For when Jacob returns late from chasing butterflies, 'it was after twelve when he crossed the lawn and he saw his mother in the bright room, playing patience, sitting up'.[79] In these examples, her sleep is displaced, made contingent on the bodies of others.

And when fear enters the nursery, it is Mrs Flanders who explains it away: 'Think of the fairies', she whispers to Archer as a hurricane rages at sea.[80] 'What's all that water rushing in?' the child asks. 'It's only the bath water running away', Mrs Flanders hums.[81] These gentle mistruths resonate with Rainer Maria Rilke's 'Third Duino Elegy', where the mother becomes a figure of holy concealment, shielding the child from 'surging chaos'. 'You

hid much from him', Rilke writes. 'There was nowhere a creak you couldn't explain away, smiling, / as though you'd long known the floor would act that way. / And he listened and calmed down … '.[82] Betty Flanders, as well as Mrs Ramsay, performs this sacred labour: of muting the creaks in the floor, of inventing reasons for the wind, of offering narrative in place of dread. A way of standing, quietly, between a child and the abyss.

Mother:

But Betty is not only the caretaker of young children; she is also the mother of young men. Her letters to Jacob reveal a different register of maternal concern – one laced with formality, emotional restraint, and that particular kind of intimacy only visible in what remains unsaid. She addresses her letters with flourish, 'as mothers do',[83] but the content tightens, guarded by a propriety that leaves its deepest concern muted. What she wants to write – 'Don't go with bad women, do be a good boy; wear your thick shirts; and come back, come back, come back to me' – is precisely what she 'could never, never say'.[84] Only the envelope, pale blue and unassuming, bears the weight of maternal feeling. 'If the envelope lying by the biscuit box had the feelings of a mother', the narrator suggests, then 'the heart was torn by the little creak, the sudden stir' of Jacob's intimacy with Florinda, which remains offstage yet emotionally lacerating.[85] In this quiet moment, Woolf signals a rupture in the maternal field: 'Terror would come over her', the narrator writes, 'as at death, or the birth of a child'.[86] Here, the temporal poles of maternity – origin and end – converge into a single, unbearable register. Beckett gives this collapse its most pitiless phrasing in 'Waiting for Godot': mothers, Pozzo declares, 'they give birth astride of a grave'.[87]

This is the axis upon which Woolf pivots. In this moment, 'mother' begins to shift from the domestic register of lowercase care to the capitalised monumental figure through whom national and narrative loss will be processed. As Groover notes, Jacob is born 'under a pall of … tragedy', and Woolf allows Betty to intuit that pall before it names itself as war death.[88] Her sorrow is thus steeped in foreknowledge, which comes, part and parcel, with the liminal threshold she occupies as both giver of life and death. The force of this convergence is important to Woolf, as it will resound again in *To the Lighthouse*, where Woolf literalises the maternal momento mori through the image of the skull[89]: the hollow vessel once held within the mother's body, now offered back as emblem of what she cannot preserve.[90]

This monumental Mother carries a double burden, for the shift from *mother* to *Mother* renders her further inarticulable. The capital letter signals reverence, but it also announces a collapse of language, for in English, French, and German, no word is available for a mother who has lost her child. The widow, as we've seen, is clearly defined (though by lack), as is the orphan, but the maternal mourner remains without a single

normative noun, described only by grasping phrases: *bereaved*, *at a loss*, *a mother who has lost a child*. A brief concordance of Woolf's text confirms this imbalance. This absence is a cultural silence with real consequence. As Adrienne Rich observes, the mother is expected to endure without public recognition or language adequate to her condition, for 'somehow her relationship to him is [always already] connected with death'.[91] The missing term becomes a kind of apophasis in itself. The mother's loss hovers at the edge of speech, held in the margins of a sorrow too disorganising to be absorbed into language.

Nowhere is this more visible than in the context of war. While the widow may remarry, and the orphan may be adopted, the mother who outlives her child remains unchanged in status but permanently altered in being. Davidson and Stahls note that 'maternal grief is thought to be the most persistent and profound grief',[92] but the absence of a term renders it structurally invisible. Luckins describes this grief as 'conceptually unformed', while Murphy and Nile name its expressive crisis 'the insufficiency and incommensurability of language' in the context of wartime mourning.[93] The failure of language to name the maternal mourner becomes, for Woolf, the structural problem her novel must solve through form.

Elegy without closure

To give this type of grief form, Woolf turns to the natural world. This aesthetic logic also manifests earlier in *The Voyage Out*, where, as Nick Montgomery observes, 'there is a stylised collapse of signification, a symbolic divestiture of the word', giving rise to 'a reciprocal investment in the purely focal' and a 'gathering awareness … of the disruptive and uncanny power of sound'.[94] In both novels, Woolf erodes the authority of the patriarchal word and reorients the text toward a maternal, atmospheric register, though in *Jacob's Room*, she brackets the novel with elemental and auditory ruptures: the opening chapters are marked by hurricane winds and perceived pistol shots;[95] the closing scenes echo with a salt gale and the indistinct sound of guns.

Mrs Flander's grief manifests atmospherically most obviously in the first chapter. Woolf suggests that we are meant to read her as a mourner by opening the novel with Betty's tears. We might consider the encroaching hurricane as a metaphor for Betty's grief. The 'waves show an uneasiness' that mirrors the constant 'discomfort' in Betty's mind.[96] The wind causes the 'lights … to wink and quiver' in language analogous to Betty's crying.[97] On three separate occasions, tears obscure her vision: once in the novel's opening when she bawls and blinks, causing 'the entire bay to quiver; … the lighthouse [to] wobble'.[98] Again when looking out at her garden: her 'tears made all the dahlias … undulate in red waves'.[99] And finally, when considering Captain Barfoot's proposal: 'She shook her head and was

looking through her tears at the little shifting leaves against the yellow sky'.[100] The storminess of Betty's grief is evidenced not only in the mutual quivering of the tears and the lights but also in the dahlias that undulate in waves and in the wind that 'tear[s] across the coast', a dramatic word play between verb (to tear) and noun (the drops associated with crying) that links her distress with disturbances in her environment.[101]

Later in the novel, before the war has a name, it arrives in wind. Mrs Flanders – referred to in this moment as 'the widow lady' – lies in bed while Jacob travels abroad, and the wind begins to rise. A 'salt gale' slips through her open window. It's a gust not unlike the hurricane Betty encounters in Scarborough, edged with the residue of tears and sea: 'Now the agitation of the air uncovered a racing star. Now it was dark. Now one after another lights were extinguished. Now great towns – Paris – Constantinople – London – were black as strewn rocks'.[102] Each successive *now* marks a vanishing. Rumours of war begin to spread throughout the world by negation – light extinguished, cities darkened. The gale functions as a hinge that links Betty's personal sorrow to the atmospheric pressure of a world inching toward war. As in *The Voyage Out*, where a storm breaks over the hotel on the night of Rachel's death, this weather, too, gives shape to grief.

The same atmospheric unease that we see in the opening chapter returns on the eve of the Great War as Betty lies awake in her bed, half-asleep, half-alert.[103] Just as the 'volley of pistol-shots' startled her earlier in the novel, another affective rupture resounds: 'Guns?' she wonders. 'Not at this distance', she reassures herself. 'It is the sea'.[104] But Woolf does not resolve the question. Instead, the novel offers another escape to sound: 'Again, far away, she heard the dull sound, as if nocturnal women were beating great carpets. … But were the chickens safe? Was that someone moving downstairs? Rebecca with the toothache. No. The nocturnal women were beating great carpets'.[105] The simile is deceptively, domestically ordinary. The women are plural – the beating, a collective attempt at grief, for to beat a rug is to release what clings to it. The image binds together two kinds of sound: first, the rhythmic labour of domesticity, followed by the muffled roll of a funeral drum.[106] This image anticipates the war's dispersal of grief into atmosphere. With every strike, dust rises and hangs in the air; like grief, it is diffuse and persistent, impossible to grasp and nearly impossible to get rid of.

From this muffled rhythm, Woolf moves to the novel's last sound. Just as Terence calls, 'Rachel! Rachel!' into the quiet that follows her death,[107] and Lily Briscoe screams for her dead friend 'Mrs Ramsay! Mrs Ramsay!,[108] Bonamy's final cry – 'Jacob! Jacob!' – rings out into a room that offers no reply.[109] These invocations sound the absence of the dead. Apophasis begins here in the emotional reflex of grief, where what is most present is what is no longer there. In other words, the name spoken aloud becomes a

negative imprint, a call that marks its loss in echo. Betty's whispered concerns, her sleepless nights, her stories to soothe her boys – all these maternal gestures gather in the silence that follows. Their tenderness lingers, but their object is gone.

Just as Woolf renders Jacob Flanders as a commemorative abstraction – a figure whose 'statue'-like'[110] stillness absorbs the projections of a grieving public – so too does she shape Betty Flanders into a vessel of ambient sorrow, her maternal grief diffused across the novel's elemental textures. Alice Kelly has noted that Jacob's indeterminacy invites 'imaginative imposition by others', aligning him with the aesthetic of the cenotaph and the cultural machinery of the Unknown Soldier, both of which depend upon symbolic vacancy in order to function as sites of collective mourning.[111] Jacob's indistinctness, his spectral resistance to narrative closure, becomes the condition of his legibility as an Everyman of the Great War. His is a body unpictured, a life unlived, a name repeated only after its referent has disappeared. He becomes, in effect, the perfect emblem of wartime sacrifice – anonymous, absent, elegizable.

But if Jacob stands as the surrogate for a generation lost to war – 'just one of many young men killed in the mass tumult of war', as Bunting writes – Betty Flanders endures as the elegiac counterweight.[112] She is the one who survives and whose suffering remains illegible within the dominant structures of remembrance. She does not fit into the monumental grammar of national grief, rather she exists at the periphery of public commemoration. Woolf's elegiac innovation is thus philosophical: she builds into her narrative structure an apophatic ethics, where the inability to articulate becomes the condition for reverent witnessing. As an Everywoman of the Great War, Betty does not testify; she attends. Claire Buck reminds us that the trench became the site of wartime authenticity, relegating women's experiences to the margins of literary form and cultural recognition.[113] Woolf counters that logic by redefining the coordinates of elegy itself.

As I've suggested, Jacob lends Woolf's novel its name, but it is Betty, bereaved widow and mother, who gives it its tone. Her sorrow opens the novel and shadows its close. As Woolf's figure of affective apophasis, Betty persists through the reverberation of what is withheld. Like the divine in negative theology, she takes shape in the spaces language cannot reach, and it is through her, finally, that Woolf teaches us to read elegy not as closure but as presence sustained through silence.

A century after the Great War, the conditions Woolf exposed remain familiar. The language of public mourning still falters before private loss, whether in the aftermath of war, pandemic, or personal grief. Women's sorrow, especially when domestic or maternal, continues to fall outside collective recognition. *Jacob's Room* is here to remind us that the struggle to

make grief speak is ongoing. The novel begins and ends with a cry – Arthur's 'Ja – cob!' on the Cornish shore followed, years later, by Bonamy's reverberating call.[114] Between them lies a mother's silence, which holds both voices in suspension. The symmetry carries Jacob's absence across the novel, moving from the mother's private loss to the public mourning that surrounds a generation.

In Woolf's hands, Betty Flanders becomes the monument the war forgot to build.

Notes

1. There is a robust scholarly conversation around Woolf's elegiac form. See: Tammy Clewell, 'Consolation Refused: Virginia Woolf, The Great War, and Modernist Mourning', *Modern Fiction Studies*, 50.1 [2004], pp. 197–223; Margaret Higonnet, 'The Great War and the Female Elegy: Female Lamentation and Silence in Global Contexts', *The Global South*, 1.2 [2007], pp. 120–36; Jahan Ramazani, *Poetry of Mourning* [University of Chicago Press, 1994]; David Shaw, *Elegy and Paradox: Testing the Conventions* [Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins, 1994]; Karen Smythe, 'Virginia Woolf's Elegiac Enterprise', *NOVEL: A Forum on Fiction*, 26.1 [1992] pp. 64–79; Mark Spilka, *Virginia Woolf's Quarrel with Grieving* [Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1980]; Kathleen Wall, 'Significant Form in *Jacob's Room*: Ekphrasis and the Elegy', *Texas Studies in Literature and Language*, 44.2 (2002), pp. 302–23.
2. Virginia Woolf, 'On Not Knowing Greek', in *The Common Reader* (New York: Harcourt, 1984), p. 31.
3. Elaine Scarry, *The Body in Pain: The Making and Unmaking of the World* (New York: Oxford UP, 1985), p. 172.
4. The aesthetic implications of this condition animate the broader modernist movement. In James Joyce's *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man*, Stephen's terror before the 'dark mutinous shadows' of his childhood surfaces less in description than in the rhythm and fragmentation of the prose; in D.H. Lawrence's *The Rainbow*, Ursula Brangwen's grief and erotic confusion manifest in sensory saturation and narrative distortion rather than confession; in E.M. Forster's *Howards End*, Margaret Schlegel's subdued emotional landscape unfolds through silence and social indirection (Jame Joyce, *A Portrait of the Artist as a Young Man* [New York: B.W. Huebsch, 1916]; D. H. Lawrence, *The Rainbow* [London: Methuen & Co., 1915]; E.M. Forster, *Howards End* [London: Edward Arnold, 1910]). Woolf's own fiction repeatedly returns to the expressive limits of language – Clarissa Dalloway's sense of disembodiment in *Mrs. Dalloway*, Mrs Ramsay's quiet internal intensities in *To the Lighthouse*, and Jacob Flanders's posthumous absence all suggest that affect operates most powerfully at the edges of what exceeds articulation.
5. Sigmund Freud, 'Thoughts for the Times on War and Death', in James Strachey (ed.), *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud* (London: Hogarth Press, 1957), Vol. XIV, p. 278.
6. Paul Fussell, *The Great War and Modern Memory* (Oxford University Press, 1975), p. 170.
7. Quoted in Fussell, *The Great War*, p. 167.

8. Shaw, *Elegy and Paradox*, p. 5.
9. Early criticism, beginning with Winifred Holtby's 1932 study, recognised *Jacob's Room* as an attempt to grasp what disappears when a young man dies in war (Winifred Holtby, *Virginia Woolf: A Critical Memoir* [London: Wishart & Co., 1932]). Wall has extended this insight to the formal level, identifying in the novel's proleptic structures and fractured narration an elegiac grammar already at work from the opening pages. As Wall notes, the novel does not retrospectively impose Jacob's death upon an otherwise coherent narrative; rather, its structure from the beginning anticipates loss, suggesting that grief precedes death as both tone and form (Wall, 'Significant Form in *Jacob's Room*', pp. 308, 300).
10. Virginia Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, annotated and introduced by Vara Neverow (New York: Harcourt, 2008), p. 187.
11. Jahan Ramazani, *Poetry of Mourning;* Melissa F. Zeiger, Beyond Consolation (Ithaca, NY: Cornell UP, 1997); Clewell, 'Consolation Refused'.
12. Woolf's rendering of silence anticipates questions that feminist theorists continue to raise about who is heard and whose losses are recognised. As Judith Butler observes, grievability is unevenly distributed: some lives 'are not considered lives at all' and therefore 'cannot be humanised' or publicly mourned (*Precarious Life* [New York: Verso, 2006], p. 34). Sara Ahmed likewise reminds us that 'silence is not simply the absence of speech; it is an effect of how speech is heard – or not heard – within a structure that decides whose voice counts' (Sara Ahmed, *The Cultural Politics of Emotion* [Edinburgh University Press, 2004], p. 37). Betty Flanders inhabits both conditions. She grieves in a world that provides no language for her loss, and her silence becomes the trace of that exclusion
13. Brian Massumi, *Parables for the Virtual: Movement, Affect, Sensation* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2002), p. 27.
14. Ahmed, *The Cultural Politics of Emotion,* p. 11.
15. Virginia Woolf, *Kew Gardens* in *The Complete Shorter Fiction of Virginia* Woolf (New York: Mariner, 1989: date), p. 94.
16. Sigmund Freud, 'Mourning and Melancholia' (1917) in James Strachey (ed.), *The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud* (London: Hogarth Press, 1957), Vol. XIV, pp. 243–58.
17. Svetlana Boym, *The Future of Nostalgia* (New York: Basic Books, 2001).
18. Jacques Derrida, *Specters of Marx*, (New York: Routledge, 2006).
19. Virginia Woolf, *The Voyage Out*, edited and introduced by Lorna Sage (Oxford UP, 1992); Virginia Woolf, *To the Lighthouse*, annotated and introduced by Mark Hussey (New York: Harcourt, 2005).
20. Patricia Laurence proposes that Woolf's silences function both thematically and formally as *practices* of meaning-making. Laurence's reading of silence emphasises Woolf's shift from event to interruption as a feminist response to the limits of language. Though Laurence does not explicitly use the term 'apophasis', her work aligns with its rhetorical and affective implications, particularly in framing silence as a space of epistemological resistance and emotional resonance (Patricia Ondek Laurence, *The Reading of Silence: Virginia Woolf in the English Tradition* [CA: Stanford UP, 1991]).
21. In *The Gender of Modernity*, Felski interrogates how narratives of modernity have traditionally been constructed around male experience, rendering women peripheral to the dominant historical and intellectual trajectories of

modern life. Her analysis helps contextualise the cultural pressures Woolf's women characters face, and the narrative strategies Woolf employs to resist those pressures (Rita Felski, *The Gender of Modernity* [*Harvard UP, 1995*]).

22. Holtby, *Virginia Woolf*, p. 216.
23. Kate Flint, 'Revising *Jacob's Room*: Virginia Woolf, Women, and Language', *The Review of English Studies*, 42.167 (1991), pp. 363–4.
24. Vara Neverow, 'Introduction' to *Jacob's Room* by Virginia Woolf (New York: Harcourt, 2008), p. lv.
25. Galen Bunting, '"*Brought up in an Illusion": Jacob's Room* as Modernist Anti-War Novel', *Woolf Studies Annual,* 30 (2024), pp. 7, 12.
26. Alice Kelly, *Commemorative Modernisms: Women Writers, Death and the First World War* (Edinburgh University Press, 2020), p. 204.
27. David Bradshaw, 'Winking, Buzzing, Carpet-Beating: Reading *Jacob's Room*', in *Annual Virginia Woolf Birthday Lectures.* (Camden, England: Virginia Woolf Society of Great Britain, 2003), p. 28.
28. Ibid., p. 9.
29. We must also consider that Florinda is pregnant – 'no doubt about it', and questions remain about whether Jacob has fathered any children (Ibid., p. 178).
30. Linda Martin, 'Elegy and the Unknowable Mind in *Jacob's Room*', *Studies in the Novel*, 47.2 (2015), pp. 180, 187.
31. Martin, 'Elegy and the Unknowable Mind', p. 177.
32. Virginia Woolf, *Mrs. Dalloway*, annotated and with an introduction by Bonnie Kime Scott (New York, Harcourt, 2005).
33. Susan R. Grayzel, *Women's Identities at War: Gender, Motherhood, and Politics in Britain and France During the First World War* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1999), p. 228.
34. Nosheen Khan, *Women's Poetry of the First World War (New York: Harvester Wheatsheaf,* 1998*).*
35. Carol Action, 'Writing and Waiting: The First World War Correspondence between Vera Brittain and Roland Leighton', *Gender & History* vol. 11.1 (1999), pp. 54–83.
36. Flint, 'Revising *Jacob's Room*', p. 364.
37. Edward L. Bishop, 'Introduction', in *Jacob's Room* by Virginia Woolf. Edited and with an introduction and notes by Edward L. Bishop (Oxford: Shakespeare Head Press, 2004), xi-xxxvii; Edward L. Bishop, *Virginia Woolf's Jacob's Room: The Holograph Draft* (New York: Pace UP, 2010)
38. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 4.
39. I use the female pronoun here purposefully. The word *widower* is one of the rare instances in English where the masculine form is derived by modifying an originally feminine noun, *widow*. This inversion of normative gendered morphology underscores how widowhood has historically been marked and defined as a feminine condition, with the masculine variant appearing only as a linguistic afterthought.
40. Marjo Buitelaar, 'Widows' Worlds: Representations and Realities', in Jan Bremmer and Lourens Van Den Bosch (eds.), *Between Poverty and the Pyre: Moments in the History of Widowhood* (New York: Routledge, 1995), p. 10–12.
41. Rachel Vinrace's conversation with Richard Dalloway in *Melymbrosia* offers an early glimpse of Woolf's discomfort with the rhetorical appropriation of widows into the imperial machinery. Richard's metaphor of the citizen as a 'screw' in the 'complicated machine' of the state effectively evacuates the

widow's subjectivity. In contrast, Rachel imagines the widow as a figure of longing and spiritual inquiry, one whose affections are left 'untouched' (Virginia Woolf, *Melymbrosia*, edited and introduced by Louise DeSalvo [Berkely, CA: Cleiss Press, 2002], p. 76). The irreconcilability of these visions signals Woolf's emerging awareness of the ideological containment and emotional illegibility of women's grief.

42. Erika Kuhlman, *Of Little Comfort: War Widows, Fallen Soldiers, and the Remaking of the Nation After the Great War* (New York: NYU Press, 2012), p. 3.
43. Richard van Emden, *The Quick and the Dead: Fallen Soldiers and their Families in the Great War* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2011), p. 303.
44. Kuhlman, *Of Little Comfort*, pp. 2–3.
45. Christine Froula, 'Out of the Chrysalis: Female Initiation and Female Authority in Virginia Woolf's *The Voyage Out*', *Tulsa Studies in Women's Literature*, 5.1 (1985), p. 63; Molly Hite suggests that Woolf was not always the best at championing other women. Writing of the 'critically-acclaimed and widely-read group' of female authors preceding her, Hite explains that Woolf's engagement with them was 'at best ambivalent'. In 'refusing to mention these female writers in her great canon-forming polemics', Hite argues, 'Woolf helped make them forgotten by much of twentieth-century literary history' (Molly Hite, 'The Public Woman and the Modernist Turn: Virginia Woolf's *The Voyage Out* and Elizabeth Robins's *My Little Sister*', *Modernism/modernity*, 17.3 [2010], p. 523).
46. Susan Bennet Smith, 'What the Duke of Wellington is Doing in *Jacob's Room*', *Virginia Woolf Miscellany*, 36 (1991), p. 2.
47. Ibid., p. 13.
48. Alex Zwerdling, '*Jacob's Room*: Woolf's Satiric Elegy', *ELH*, 48.4 (1981), p. 909.
49. Ibid., p. 897.
50. Bishop, 'Introduction', p. xxviii.
51. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 8.
52. Ibid., p. 3.
53. Ibid., p. 3.
54. Ibid., pp. 20, 13.
55. Ibid., p. 4.
56. Ibid., p. 14.
57. Woolf, *The Voyage Out.*
58. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 14.
59. Ibid., p. 12.
60. Ibid., p. 13.
61. Ibid., p. 13.
62. Ibid., p. 12.
63. Ibid., p. 26.
64. Ibid., p. 7
65. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 21.
66. Wall, 'Significant Form in *Jacob's Room*', p. 308.
67. Ibid., p. 300.
68. Claudia Siebrecht, 'The Female Mourner: Gender and the Moral Economy of Grief During the First World War', *Gender and the First World War* (Oxford University Press, 2013), pp, 144–62.

69. Shilo McGiff and Valerie Favre, 'What is a Portmanteau Woolf? What is the Woolfian Portmanteau?', *Virginia Woolf Miscellany*, 99 (2002), 1–2.
70. Ibid., p. 1–2.
71. Rita Felski, *Hooked: Art and Attachment* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2020).
72. Sara Ruddick, *Maternal Thinking: Toward a Politics of Peace* (Beacon Press, 1989), p. 22.
73. Woolf, *To the Lighthouse*, p. 65.
74. Woolf would later turn this moment into principle in *A Room of One's Own*, where she writes that 'a woman must have money and a room of her own if she is to write fiction'(Virginia Wolf, *A Room of One's Own* [Oxford World Classics, 2015], p. 3). The letter broken by Archer's call becomes a small version of the larger structural problem Woolf identifies as the impossibility of sustained creative labour under constant interruption. The maternal act of writing is undone by the very relationality that defines it.
75. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 7.
76. Ibid., p. 8.
77. Ibid., p. 19.
78. Ibid., pp. 39, 17.
79. Ibid., p. 21.
80. Ibid., p. 8.
81. Ibid., p. 9.
82. Quoted in Adrienne Rich, *Of Woman Born: Motherhood as Experience and Institution* (New York: W. W. Norton, 1976), p. 190.
83. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 94.
84. Ibid., p. 94.
85. Ibid., p. 95.
86. Ibid., p. 95.
87. Samuel Beckett, 'Waiting for Godot' (New York: Grove Press, 1954), p. 80.
88. Kristina K. Groover, *The Interrupted Moment: A View of Virginia Woolf's Novels* (Lausanne, Switzerland: Peter Lang, 1995), p. 68.
89. Both *To the Lighthouse* and *Jacob's Room* evoke the convergence of maternity and mortality through the recurring image of a skull. In *To the Lighthouse*, the maternal gesture of shielding her children from death is literalised when Mrs Ramsay wraps a shawl around the skull in their nursery – an act of care that ultimately proves futile as war and illness later claim her children and herself. The shawl, briefly concealing the horror of mortality, eventually slips, exposing what was always beneath. *Jacob's Room* opens with a similar moment: young Jacob, momentarily lost on the beach, discovers a skull just as his mother frantically searches for him. The image recurs in the novel's final scene, where a ram's skull crowns the doorframe of Jacob's now-empty room.
90. Bunting, '"*Brought up in an Illusion*"', p. 11; Neverow, 'Introduction', p. lxxxi.
91. Rich, *Of Woman Born*, p. 188.
92. Deborah Davidson and Helena Stahls, 'Maternal Grief: Creating an Environment for Dialogue', *Journal of the Motherhood Initiative*, 1.2 (1999), p. 16.
93. Tanja Luckins, *The Gates of Memory: Australian People's Experiences and Memories of Loss and the Great War* (Western Australia: Fremantle Arts Centre Press, 2004), pp. 1–3; Ffion Murphy and Richard Nile, 'Writing

Silence: Grieving Mothers and the Literature of War', in D. Das and S. Dasgupta (eds.), *Claiming Space for Australian's Women's Writing* (2017), p. 43.

94. Nick Montgomery, 'Virginia Woolf and the Aesthetics of Mourning', *Twentieth Century Literature*, 38.1 (Spring 1992), p. 35.
95. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, pp. 21, 31.
96. Ibid., p. 7.
97. Ibid., p. 10.
98. Ibid., p. 3.
99. Ibid., p. 4.
100. Ibid., p. 18.
101. Ibid., p. 10.
102. Ibid., p. 169.
103. Bunting, '"*Brought up in an Illusion*"', p. 24.
104. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 185.
105. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 185. Ouditt manifests the trouble I see with traditional accountings of Betty Flanders. Of the 'great carpet' scene, she writes, 'Betty dilutes "masculine" concerns with "female" worries. Even the noise of the shell is perceived in whimsical, domestic terms' (Sharon Ouditt, *Fighting Forces, Writing Women: Identity and Ideology in the First World War* [Oxfordshire: Routledge, 1994], p. 188).
106. In Henstra's reading of women's protest mourning, she describes the 'muffled drums' of female dissent, where sonic residue replaces speech; Henstra, 'British Propaganda', p. 74.
107. Woolf, *The Voyage Out*, p. 413.
108. Woolf, *To the Lighthouse*, p. 165.
109. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 187.
110. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, p. 81, 180.
111. Kelly, *Commemorative Modernisms*, p. 136.
112. Bunting, '"*Brought up in an Illusion*"', p. 6.
113. Claire Buck, *Women's Writing of the First World War: An Anthology*. (Oxford University Press, 1998).
114. Woolf, *Jacob's Room*, pp. 4, 187.

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